



2000 BC

4000 years ago in Iraq, the Babylonians showed zeros by leaving small gaps between wedge marks on clay, but they didn't think of the gaps as numbers in their own right.



Babylonia



India

350 BC The ancient Greeks were brilliant at maths, but they **hated** the idea of zero. The Greek philosopher Aristotle said zero should be **illegal** because it made a mess of sums when he tried to divide by it.

1 AD The Romans didn't have a zero because their counting system didn't need one. After all, if there's nothing to count, why would you need a number?

(Some people used to think the number 1 was also pointless, since you only have a ...

... *number* of things if you have more than one.)

Even if the Romans had thought of zero, it wouldn't have worked with their cumbersome counting system, which used long

lists of letters like MMCCCXVCXIII.



North Africa



Central America

600 AD Indian mathematicians invented the modern zero. They had a counting system in which the **position** of a digit affected its value, and they used dots or circles to show gaps. **Why a circle?** Because Indians once used pebbles in sand to do sums, and a circle looked like the gap where a pebble had been removed.



Arabia



Europe

1150 AD Zero came to Europe in the 12th century, when Indian numerals spread from Arab countries. People soon realized that doing sums was much easier when you have *nothing* to help you count!